

Beaten TRACK

The prime minister uses the inauguration of the Anantnag-Qazigund rail link to renew the dialogue process, but there's little enthusiasm as major players remain inflexible

By Aijaz Hussain

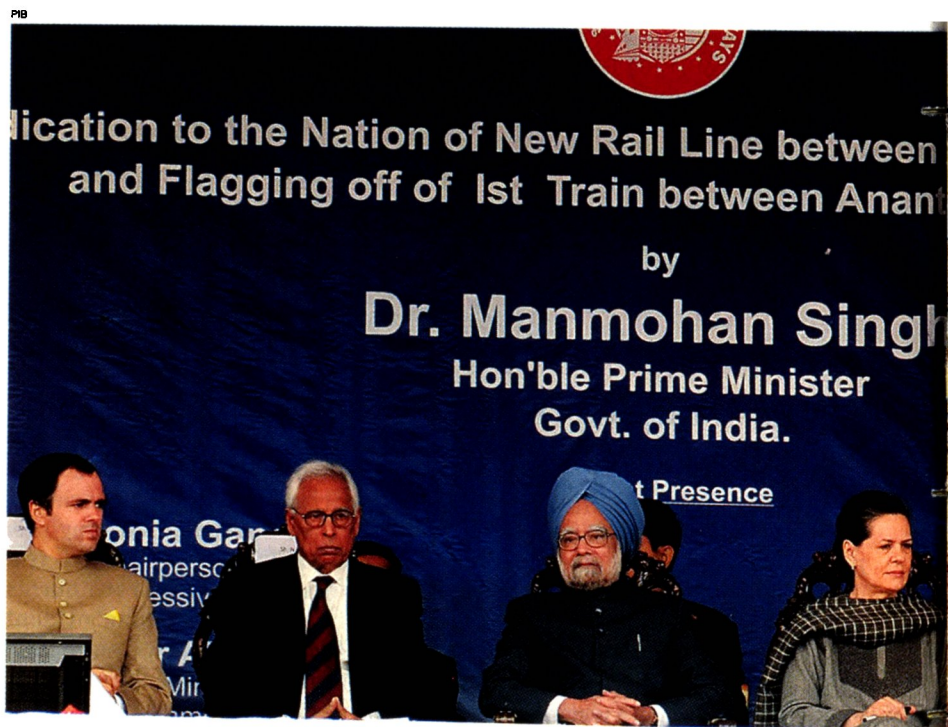
History tells us that whenever Delhi talks about a bilateral dialogue for peace in Kashmir, it evokes scepticism in the Valley. Much was already being made of the dialogue offer with separatists before Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's visit to Srinagar last week. Before him, Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram acknowledged the importance of dealing with the political aspect of the issue, but Manmohan mostly stressed the economic and development side. Extending a fresh olive branch to resistance that Indian rule has historically met in Kashmir, he said, "We have to carry all stakeholders with us to achieve a permanent and peaceful reconciliation so that we can concentrate on an ambitious development agenda that will lead to economic revival and reconstruction." He did not show any signs of dealing with the tough six-decade-old political question, but renewed the dialogue offer, basing it on the "improved" security situation in Kashmir, saying "we are turning a corner" in the state.

Hardly had the prime minister's entourage left Kashmir's airspace that developments began flying in the face of his assertions. Pre-paid cell-phone connections—a lifeline for three million users in Jammu and Kashmir—were banned for security concerns. As if this was not enough, the cricket team of the Services that represents the Central armed forces, hundreds of thousands of whom are deployed in the Valley, refused to play a Ranji Trophy match in Srinagar citing safety reasons. It left the patron of the ruling National Conference (NC) and Union Minister Farooq Abdullah

fuming. "The Services have negated what the prime minister, the defence minister and the home minister have said, that Kashmir is normal. They want us to burn all the time so that they can remain our masters," he said.

So what does the renewed call for an internal dialogue with separatists

Hurriyat Conference (APHC) Mirwaiz Umar Farooq has welcomed the offer but has kept the pressure on Delhi by repeating demands like repeal of impunity laws, withdrawal of troops and release of prisoners. While Manmohan was in Srinagar, Farooq, during a conference in London, termed



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mean? Analysts say the prime minister's fresh approach contains nothing new. While Manmohan did mention the importance of taking Pakistan on board, the dialogue offer has not generated a substantive political dynamic. Separatist leaders appear in disarray, yet their individual stances sound almost alike. Head of the 'moderate' faction of the All Parties

the gun as a "legitimate element in the political struggle of Kashmir". The prime minister's response to this, however, highlighted the value Delhi is attaching to the expected dialogue with those who "abjure" violence.

Manmohan's accommodative attitude towards Farooq has lent more credence to the head of 'hardline' faction of the APHC Syed Ali Shah Geelani's continuing posture. He has rejected outright Manmohan's platitudes in the absence of any mechanism facilitating